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Scribes Writers - May, 2003 submission

KIN IS IN

A friend (?) suggested to the Genealogy Club in Sun City that I be the guest speaker at one of their monthly meetings. This will really be a challenge for me, or a big surprise for the group, as I am not a very methodical person, who enjoys pondering over dates and intricate matters. I love action! I love people! I love love !! But best of all, I do love family.

Therefore, the Genealogy members, will not get their usual expert on how to locate dates of arrivals in Ellis Island, or how to pinpoint Mormon Temples and their endless lists of immigrants (and closet skeletons). The coordinator asked me to bring instructions or techniques in gathering data. I will share with them the purpose of my memoirs and how they fly into my mind. Shall I disclose how I quietly remain in bed at 5 AM and mentally travel back to my childhood, or young motherhood, and conjure up a strategy as to a clever, funny, and truthful way of presenting it? It would have been priceless if my grandparents and parents were able to do the same thing. Wouldn't you have found their memoirs to be precious to you? (Your family; not mine.) By 6 AM, I am at my computer, and my thoughts simply flow out.

If I come to an impasse, I put my masterpiece into " memory" and give it a rest. My recall is vivid and quite accurate. The family is familiar with what I'm doing and cheer me onward. Although I frequently share my short stories with them, one day they will get the whole kit and caboodle.

My dear mother Bella should have been a writer, but she could tell wonderful stories about her youth. She was born in Russia; Krastnostov, Valinsky Gabernia. It's quite impressive when I verbalize it with rolling R's. When she was just eighteen, she came to the United

States with her girlfriend, Deena, mostly to escape a homely cousin to whom she was betrothed. She quickly began working as a seamstress, for her uncle in Hartford, Connecticut. One weekend, she and her friend decided to see the "City", Brooklyn, New York. It was a warm summer day and many of the residents sat on their stoops drinking lemonade. As Bella strolled by, the mother of a family group glanced admiringly at her and whispered in Yiddish, "Ah zeesa puhnum!", which means "a sweet face". Bella acknowledged the compliment with, "Ah shayna deinkach." (A very nice thank you.) The family was startled that she understood. Her bright blue eyes and cute little nose indicated to them that she was a shicksa (gentile).

Yiddish was a language of glue because most Jews knew this universal tongue. My father came from Roumania and could speak English, Roumanian and Yiddish. As he was the oldest child of the Siegel clan, and the darling of the family, he picked up the reins and continued the conversation with the pretty stranger. She and her friend were invited to the public pool the next weekend where handsome Jack could show off his great physique. He was able to ripple his pectorals, one at a time if he chose. Beautiful Bella was smitten and they were wed six months later.

The betrothed cousin arrived a few weeks late, but stayed in the family and became Uncle Harry. When I was old enough to understand the story, I was so glad that Uncle Harry did not become my father. Harry and his future wife, Bessie, loved to eat raw onions and herring. They also laughed a great deal so it was very painful to be near them. The war broke out at that time so New York became the permanent home for the Russian immigrants. Besides, although my mother missed her family very much, she also told frightening stories of the Cossack soldiers and how they bullied and caused havoc in the Jewish villages; especially when they were drunk.

My mother was also a deceiving diplomat. She had four children and whenever we visited her, after we were grown, our picture would

be displayed on the piano. No matter which of her offspring called on her, the proper photograph appeared in the frame. Of course, there were four pictures stacked in that frame, so it was effortless to quickly produce the correct one. She probably had a spare frame if two of us appeared at the same time. Mother Bella was a mild but determined stage door mom. We started out entertaining visiting relatives. When she heard on the radio that auditions were being held for talented children, we were there. My middle sister and I took tap dance, acrobatic and piano lessons. Radio music filled our house and we were encouraged to dance with ribbons and scarves flowing. She sat with us when we did our homework, so that she could learn to speak more elequently.

Bella was also a leader, and became president of Haddasah and active in the PTA. She organized a kitty so that my third grade teacher would get a nice Christmas present from the class. Being very practical, and considering the weather, the grateful teacher received a pair of long "woolies", that warmed the cockles of her "heart".

My father had the most beautiful handwriting I had ever seen, and I was tremendously proud to have him sign my report card. His signature could have adorned the Declaration of Independence, with its' flourishes and curlicues. He was not as intellectual as Bella but he had a heart of gold, which the relatives loved to spend. He worked hard and established a fine used furniture store in Brownsville. The community loved him and he became financially successful as soon as my mother took charge of the income.

Now, these are the kind of stories I could relate at the genealogy meeting. It might encourage a few people to expand the way they think of their families without, hopefully, destroying the club.

Dates are great when remembering kin,
But mem'ries are best; they live within.

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